

TUNDRA TO TROPICS

Asia

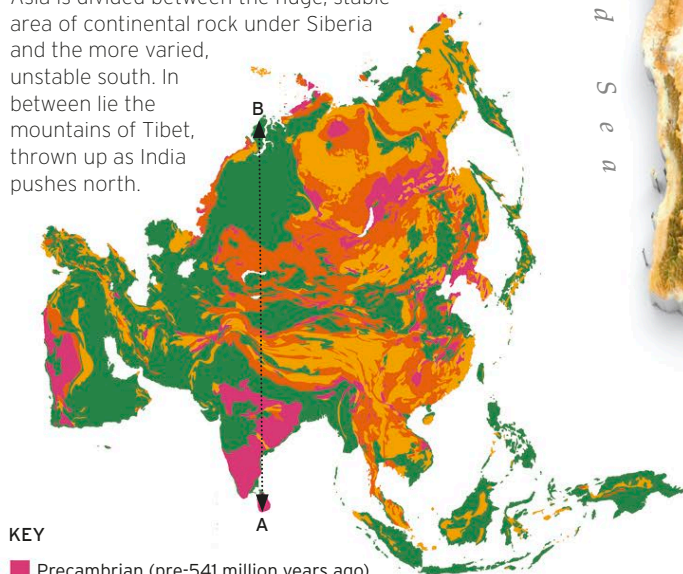
Asia is the world's largest continent, taking up almost one-third of Earth's land surface. A large part of the north is the West Siberian Plain, the largest area of flat land in the world. It is dotted with huge swamps and blanketed by dark Siberian forests, ending in the far north with bleak, open tundra—which can often be colder than the Arctic in winter. Farther south are the extensive steppe grasslands of Central Asia, merging into the Gobi Desert. Asia's other great desert is the sand sea of the Rub' al Khali, scorching across the Arabian Peninsula.

In the heart of Asia is the Tibetan Plateau. The world's highest mountains soar around it: to the north, the Altai and Tian Shan; and to the south, the Himalayas, the highest of all, rising to the peak of Everest. Beyond the mountains, to the south and east, long

stretches of land extend out into the Indian and Pacific oceans. They are cut by great rivers, filled by rain and melting snow from the mountains—the Indus and Ganges in Pakistan and India, the Mekong in Southeast Asia, and the Yellow and Yangtze in China.

GEOLOGY

Asia is divided between the huge, stable area of continental rock under Siberia and the more varied, unstable south. In between lie the mountains of Tibet, thrown up as India pushes north.



KEY

- Precambrian (pre-541 million years ago)
- Paleozoic (541-252 million years ago)
- Mesozoic (252-66 million years ago)
- Cenozoic (66 million years ago to present day)

